

DWARF

COMMON

DWARF

HUMANOID

Dwarves hail from **Zeta Hydrae II**, a high-gravity jungle-ocean world they call **Vuddar**. Immense trees rise from drowned continental shelves, their roots extending deep beneath the water while their trunks support dense canopies above the highest tides. Traditional dwarven settlements occupy these canopies, where rope bridges, suspended platforms, lifts, ladders, and climbing paths connect homes, workshops, gardens, and communal halls.

Vuddar's rapid 11.1-hour rotation, 5.4-day orbit, extreme axial tilt, active geology, two unstable satellites, and prominent ice ring produce overlapping cycles of storms, tides, changing light, and orbital debris. Dwarven communities developed around the expectation that buildings must endure movement, moisture, weight, and constant maintenance. Their reputation for careful craftsmanship began long before they reached the stars.

Dwarven reverence for tradition does not prevent them from adopting new technology. Following their revelation through **the Star Dream**, dwarven engineers rapidly applied its principles to propulsion, orbital construction, advanced metallurgy, and Drift travel. Their concern was where that technology would be used. Rather than reshape Vuddar into an industrial launch world, the clans constructed most large foundries, shipyards, laboratories, and launch facilities beyond the atmosphere.

Pre-Dream dwarves had struggled to establish a permanent orbital presence. Vuddar's 1.39 standard gravities made surface launch costly, while the planet's ring and unstable moons complicated orbital insertion, navigation, and stationkeeping. The Star Dream supplied the propulsion and navigational knowledge needed to maintain reliable routes through the crowded space surrounding the planet. Once those routes became possible, dwarven orbital industry expanded rapidly.

Vuddar lies only 5.07 light-years from Wander's origin system, placing the dwarves among the first peoples to establish direct contact with **Wander** after the Star Dream. Dwarven materials specialists, structural engineers, and shipwrights contributed to early Drift vessels, relay stations, pressure systems, and orbital infrastructure. Dwarves readily incorporated methods learned from other peoples, provided doing so did not require them to abandon responsibility for the work or surrender control of Vuddar.



By Lapse 29 PES, dwarven clans have spread throughout the **Settled Systems**. One of the largest offworld dwarven populations lives and works on **Theosis**, a sulfur world orbiting the shared center of Alpha Leonis B and Alpha Leonis C. Sealed cities remain suspended within its toxic atmosphere through a combination of buoyancy, gravitic stabilization, and enormous structural frameworks.

Theosis completes one rotation every 11,760 stamp-offset minutes and one orbit every 1,322,496 stamp-offset minutes. During the nearest portion of its eccentric orbit, changes in stellar heating and gravitational conditions produce violent atmospheric shear. This recurring period is formally classified as periastron atmospheric compression and commonly called the **Shredder Passage**. Dwarven crews maintain the pressure envelopes, stabilization systems, structural supports, and docking assemblies that keep the buoyant cities intact.

If you want to play a proud and stubborn artisan who carries their home through their work, embraces useful knowledge without surrendering their traditions, and refuses to place convenience above responsibility, you should play a dwarf.

YOU MIGHT...

- ◆ Place your personal and clan reputation behind every repair, design, or inspection you complete.
- ◆ Adopt foreign technology enthusiastically while resisting attempts to introduce disruptive industry to Vuddar.
- ◆ Maintain detailed plans for your next pilgrimage home, even when service obligations make returning uncertain.

OTHERS PROBABLY...

- ◆ Assume you are a miner, mechanic, engineer, or inspector regardless of your actual profession.
- ◆ Trust work bearing your personal mark more readily than an Erbium compliance certificate.
- ◆ Mistake your protection of Vuddarian traditions for fear of technological or cultural change.

PHYSICAL DESCRIPTION

Dwarves typically stand around 4 feet tall and possess broad, densely muscled frames. Most weigh between 175 and 250 pounds. Their compact proportions, thick bones, powerful legs, and low centers of gravity developed under Vuddar's strong surface gravity. Dwarves raised offworld retain these dense builds and often appear unusually stable and physically powerful in lower-gravity environments.

Vuddarian dwarves are capable climbers. Their broad hands, strong fingers, flexible ankles, and ridged soles provide reliable purchase on wet bark, ropes, ladders, and metal grating. Powerful shoulders and forearms help them support their weight during long vertical climbs through canopy settlements. Their short stature is well suited to moving beneath crowded branches and through the confined maintenance spaces common in both Vuddarian and orbital architecture.

A dwarf's most noticeable physical feature is often their hair. Dwarves of all genders grow dense, water-resistant hair that protects their skin from moisture, insects, fungal spores, chemical irritants, and the debris of industrial work. They clean and condition it with carefully prepared oils and waxes, many of which were originally produced from Vuddarian plants.

Clan customs determine how long a dwarf may grow their hair at different ages and stages of life. Length does not usually mean that the hair is worn loose. Long beards and coifs are folded, looped, braided, wrapped, or pinned close to the body so that they do not catch on machinery, climbing equipment, branches, or pressure seals. An elder's hair might extend several times their height if fully unbound.

Braiding patterns can communicate clan affiliation, age, profession, completed pilgrimages, family relationships, periods of mourning, or participation in major works. Some clans incorporate beads, metal clasps, polished wood, ring ice, or fragments of retired machinery into their hair. These additions are placed according to clan custom rather than personal ornament alone.

Neglected hair is often interpreted as a sign of illness, grief, exhaustion, or separation from one's clan. Dwarven communities treat hair care as a practical part of health and a common act of intimacy between relatives, partners, and close companions.

Dwarves reach physical maturity around age 25, though most clans require additional rites before recognizing a dwarf as a full adult. These rites normally require a pilgrimage to Vuddar and cannot be completed entirely through relay participation or within an offworld clanholding. Dwarves typically live for up to 350 years.

SOCIETY

Dwarves revere Vuddar slightly more than they revere their clans, though many consider the distinction meaningless. Vuddar is the world that formed the clans, while the clans preserve their connection to it across distance and generations.

A clan is more than a biological family. It can include adopted children, sworn households, apprentices, married partners, rescued dependents, and people who have earned permanent inclusion through service. A dwarf who encounters a confirmed member of their clan on a distant station can expect food, temporary shelter, help contacting relatives, and assistance navigating local institutions, even when the two have never met.

Clan obligation does not guarantee affection or agreement. Two dwarves may dislike one another while still believing that allowing the other to become homeless, stranded, or medically abandoned would dishonor them both. This expectation frequently brings clans into conflict with employment contracts that attempt to make workers individually responsible for circumstances their relatives consider a shared obligation.

Most clans maintain one or more **clanholdings**. A clanholding may serve as a residence, workshop, archive, mutual-aid center, shrine, social hall, legal office, and temporary shelter. The oldest holdings are located on Vuddar or within its orbital settlements, while large diaspora clans maintain additional holdings on Theosis and throughout major industrial systems.

A dwarf's work is understood as a permanent statement about the person and clan behind it. Finished objects, repairs, inspection records, and structural designs commonly bear the marks of the dwarves responsible for them. These marks do not promise that the work can never fail. They state that the dwarf inspected the work honestly, disclosed every defect they recognized, and accepts responsibility for the quality of what they completed.

Concealing a defect is considered more shameful than making an honest error. A hidden weakness may kill people long after the person who concealed it is dead. Maintenance therefore carries the same dignity as invention, since repair allows the work of previous generations to remain safe and useful.

Erbium Industries exploits this sense of responsibility through **craft warrants**. A dwarf who signs an inspection may be held personally or financially responsible for later failure, even when management rejected the recommended repairs, withheld necessary materials, imposed an inadequate deadline, or altered the stamped maintenance record. The company celebrates dwarven accountability while using it to redirect liability away from corporate administration.

Most clans expect adult dwarves to return to Vuddar once every quarter-lapse, approximately once every eight standard years, for a practice commonly translated as **reorientation**. During this pilgrimage, a dwarf reconnects with their clan's home territory, studies changes to Vuddar, participates in communal maintenance, renews family and professional relationships, and completes any rites appropriate to their age.

Reorientation is not treated as leisure. A returning dwarf may spend much of the pilgrimage repairing canopy structures, tending ancestral trees, teaching apprentices, preserving records, or caring for elders. Dwarves returning from distant systems are also expected to bring useful knowledge home, though clans argue extensively over which offworld practices should be adopted.

Employers require reorientation leave to be requested well in advance. Valuable specialists may receive protected leave and paid transportation, while workers classified as replaceable are often told that operational necessity requires postponement. A dwarf who misses several reorientations is not usually rejected by their clan, but they may feel increasingly uncertain whether their habits still reflect Vuddarian life.

Following the establishment of **the Great Volunteering**, dwarven clans resisted efforts to make Vuddar a regular host world. Their campaigning in late Lapse 4 PES resulted in Settled Systems Code **A4%9&4-7**, the **Vuddarian Cultural Sanctuary Exemption**. The provision exempts qualifying residents, clan institutions, ecological custodians, and facilities physically located on Vuddar from ordinary Great Volunteering selection and hosting requirements.

The exemption protects Vuddar as a jurisdiction rather than dwarves as an ancestry. Dwarves living or working offworld can still be selected. Some have been involuntarily enrolled after a residence credential identified their worksite rather than Vuddar, a pilgrimage record failed to synchronize, or a clanholding was classified as commercial housing. Erbium describes these incidents as credential discrepancies.

BELIEFS

Dwarves follow many religions and philosophies, but most dwarven traditions treat Vuddar as a sacred inheritance that no individual clan or generation owns. The planet is inhabited, cultivated, harvested, and altered, but every alteration creates an obligation to understand what was changed and maintain what was built.

Many dwarves interpret the Star Dream as an invitation to leave Vuddar without turning the home world into a launch platform. The revelation opened the sky and supplied the knowledge needed to cross it. It did not erase responsibility for the land, water, trees, and settlements that existed before it.

The orbital civilization surrounding Vuddar reflects this interpretation. Foundries, shipyards, laboratories, and large industrial habitats can expand beyond the atmosphere while construction on the planet itself remains subject to clan review, environmental scrutiny, and local consent.

Dwarven ethics place considerable weight on accurate craftsmanship. A hidden defect is a lie that continues acting upon the world after the liar is gone. A repair performed honestly may be remembered more favorably than an impressive structure built carelessly. Dwarves consequently preserve records of failure alongside records of achievement.

Clan crystals embody the connection between home, ancestry, and individual labor. Each crystal began within a living Vuddarian tree, passed through clan hands, and became part of the weapon or tool carried by a particular dwarf. The object is expected to change during the dwarf's life without losing the crystal that connects each version.

Some dwarves believe Erbium Industries performs necessary work by maintaining the infrastructure connecting the Settled Systems. Others consider the company incapable of stewardship because it treats maintained systems as property, traditions as labor resources, and responsibility as a means of assigning liability.

Popular Edicts disclose defects in work bearing your name, preserve what future generations will depend upon, support members of your clan, return useful knowledge to Vuddar, maintain your clan crystal, learn from craftspeople outside your tradition

Popular Anathema sell or deliberately abandon your clan crystal, conceal a dangerous defect, claim another person's work as your own, alter Vuddar without communal consent, invoke clan obligation solely to trap someone in debt or service, destroy functioning work merely to sell its replacement

SAMPLE NAMES

Aode, Bongrun, Duravor, Gontun, Hondue, Karvak, Morakt, Nerlond, Ontz, Quarnot, Vog, Zormuid

Dwarven names are usually accompanied by a clan name in formal settings. A dwarf may also accumulate occupational titles, pilgrimage names, or project names over a long life. A title does not necessarily indicate leadership. It records the dwarf's recognized participation in a clan, settlement, or significant work.

Examples include **Aode of Clan Tavran**, **Duravor Three>Returns**, **Hondue Ringwright**, **Karvak, Signatory of the Sixth Buttress**, **Nerlond of the Theosis Holding**, and **Vog Under-Canopy**.

OTHER INFORMATION

VUDDAR

Vuddar is a warm, high-gravity jungle-ocean world orbiting the white dwarf Zeta Hydrae. Water covers slightly more than half of the planet, while dense and complex life occupies most habitable regions. Immense trees root themselves into drowned mineral shelves and rise above the tides, creating vertically layered ecosystems within their trunks and canopies.

Traditional settlements extend from docks and submerged root chambers to residential branches, upper gardens, observatories, and launch platforms above the canopy. Structures are designed to survive high gravity, strong winds, heavy rainfall, rapid changes in weather, and the movement of living trees.

Vuddar's 11.1-hour day, 5.4-day year, and extreme axial tilt produce rapid changes in stellar exposure. The oceans and dense atmosphere moderate the worst temperature shifts, though storms and seasonal transitions can develop quickly. Dwarven calendars account for rotational days, orbital seasons, tides, ring shadows, and the changing positions of the moons.

Large-scale heavy industry is restricted on Vuddar. Most advanced manufacturing occurs in orbit, with finished materials and equipment transported down to the canopy settlements. This arrangement preserves the home world while making the space surrounding it heavily industrialized.

THE RING AND MOONS

Vuddar possesses a stable ice ring and two unstable satellites. The ring is visible across much of the planet and has influenced dwarven calendars, navigation, architecture, and visual art. It also provides water and other volatile resources to orbital settlements without requiring extraction from Vuddar's oceans.

"The wielding of radiance to elevate the essential aspects of the world"

Domain's suns are actually magical shards that produce light, heat, and Radiance.

The primary radiance's are: yellow radiance (Body/Material), blue radiance (Mind/Cerebral), and red radiance (Spirit/Ethereal).

An elevancer can use their Prismacs to refract their radiance reserves to the respective Tertiary or Secondary radiance.

When an elevancer depletes their radiance reserves, they become dimmed (drained of color), and must rest to restore their reserves.

Elevancy schools: Evoker, Psion, Mystic

Elevancy practioner: Elevancer

Elevancy Prismacs: Spirit, Body, and Mind

Prime Essences: Ethereal, Material, Cerebral

Prime Essential Aspects: Will (Spirit/Ethereal), Inspiration (Spirit/Ethereal), Forces (Body/Material), Elements (Body/Material), Emotion (Mind/Cerebral), and Thought (Mind/Cerebral)

Twin Essential Aspects: Time (Spirit & Body/Ethereal & Material), Fate (Spirit & Mind), and Perception (Body & Mind)

Zeta Hydrae II-II is a large cratered moon with low gravity, tidal heating, mineral deposits, water ice, and a suspected subsurface ocean. It supports mines, laboratories, buried habitats, and old clan installations. Its unstable orbit requires constant monitoring and periodic relocation of surface infrastructure.

Zeta Hydrae II-III is a much smaller asteroid-like body with almost negligible gravity. Early dwarven missions used it as a navigation marker and orbital waypoint. Modern installations include communications equipment, observatories, fuel storage, and automated tidal-monitoring systems.

The unstable movement of these bodies, combined with the ring and Vuddar's strong gravity, made pre-Dream orbital development exceptionally difficult. Modern navigation systems account for these hazards, though debris events and tidal changes still interrupt traffic.

Closer to Zeta Hydrae lies a dense belt of hot, radiation-exposed material containing rare metals. Dwarven and Erbium operations extract from the belt using shielded automated systems and short-duration crewed missions. The belt provides industrial resources without disturbing Vuddar, though the danger and cost of operating so close to the star gives Erbium considerable influence over access.

CLAN CRYSTALS

Clan crystals form within the mineralized cores of certain mature Vuddarian trees. Over centuries, these trees draw dissolved material from the shelves beneath them and deposit it into crystalline structures within their heartwood.

Clans do not ordinarily kill healthy trees to obtain crystal. Fragments are harvested from naturally fallen trees, storm damage, necessary arbor treatment, or trees that have reached the end of their lives. Each clan maintains a limited reserve associated with particular trees, territories, and family lines.

At birth or formal adoption, a dwarf receives a crystal fragment from their clan. The fragment is carved and incorporated into a one-handed weapon that commonly doubles as a practical tool. Hammers, hatchets, climbing picks, machetes, hooked cutters, short spears, and reinforced work knives are common.

Many crystals are carved to resemble a respected clan leader or ancestor. Dwarves who complete notable works may eventually have their likeness selected as the model for crystals granted to later generations.

The weapon changes throughout the dwarf's life. Handles, housings, blades, counterweights, and technological components may be repaired or replaced repeatedly. The clan crystal remains the continuous element.

Losing a clan crystal is a serious event. A dwarf may spend years attempting to recover it. When recovery is impossible, the clan determines whether another fragment can be issued and what rites must acknowledge the loss. Selling the crystal outside the clan is among the most serious taboos shared across dwarven cultures.

THEOSIS

Theosis is a captured sulfur world following an eccentric orbit around the shared center of Alpha Leonis B and Alpha Leonis C. Settled Systems registries continue to classify it as a moon because of an obsolete survey designation, though it does not orbit another planet.

Its toxic atmosphere is dominated by sulfur dioxide. Large sealed habitats remain suspended within the atmosphere through buoyancy systems, heated lift chambers, gravitic stabilization, and industrial support frames. Collectively, these aerostat settlements are commonly called the buoyant cities of Theosis.

The planet's local day lasts 11,760 stamp-offset minutes. Most residents divide this period into several work and sleep cycles rather than remaining active throughout the full rotation. Dwarven clanholdings use rotating **forge watches**, allowing maintenance crews to provide continuous coverage without organizing their lives around local sunrise and sunset.

Theosis completes its eccentric orbit in 1,322,496 stamp-offset minutes. During each closest approach, changing stellar conditions disturb the planet's atmospheric layers. Wind speed increases, stable buoyancy bands shift, docking structures experience additional strain, and exposed districts must alter their altitude or orientation.

This period is formally called **periastron atmospheric compression** and commonly called the **Shredder Passage**. It recurs roughly a dozen times during a standard lapse.

Ordinary arrivals and departures are suspended during the passage. Aerostat districts retract exposed structures, redistribute cargo, reinforce interplatform connections, increase pressure-envelope monitoring, and prepare to separate damaged sections before a failure spreads through the city.

Dwarven engineers form much of the workforce responsible for these preparations. Their work includes pressure-envelope inspection, altitude coordination, structural reinforcement, gravitic stabilization, docking support, and emergency separation planning.

Erbium Industries presents the dwarves of Theosis as models of reliability and technical sacrifice. Craft warrants allow the company to assign personal or clan liability to engineers who signed a failed inspection, even when corporate management denied the materials, staffing, or downtime required to complete the recommended work.

PLACE IN THE SETTLED SYSTEMS

Dwarves are commonly employed in orbital construction, shipbuilding, structural engineering, gravitic stabilization, industrial maintenance, materials testing, pressure-system design, extraction infrastructure, and safety inspection. Their reputation for honesty and careful workmanship gives dwarven inspectors considerable informal authority.

That reputation can become a burden. Employers routinely expect dwarves to repair unsafe systems without adequate time or materials, assume personal responsibility for inherited defects, and accept dangerous assignments because dwarven workers are considered naturally resilient.

Erbium recruitment campaigns frequently use dwarven engineers to represent reliability, tradition, and responsible progress. Many dwarves take genuine pride in the work shown in these campaigns while resenting the implication that their competence proves the company treats them fairly.

Some clans cooperate closely with Erbium and consider the relationship essential to their prosperity. Others maintain independent workshops, transportation agreements, mutual-aid funds, and off-stamp supply networks intended to reduce corporate control. Most clans contain members on both sides of that disagreement.

DWARF MECHANICS

HIT POINTS

10

SIZE

Medium

SPEED

20 feet

Climb 20 feet

ATTRIBUTE BOOSTS

Constitution, Wisdom, Free

ATTRIBUTE FLAW

Charisma

LANGUAGES

Common

Dwarven

and one regional language of your choice.

Additional languages equal to your Intelligence modifier, if it is positive. Choose from the list of common languages and any other languages to which you have access, such as languages prevalent on your home world.

CLAN CRYSTAL

At birth or formal adoption, you are given a one-handed simple weapon crafted with your clan crystal. The crystal can't be removed, and selling the weapon or crystal is a terrible taboo that earns you the disdain of other dwarves. The weapon's non-crystalline components can be repaired, replaced, or upgraded normally.

VUDDARIAN-BLOODED

You or your ancestors hailed from the jungles of Vuddar. The great trunks of Vuddarian trees are rooted into underwater shelves, and their immense canopies provide the planet's principal habitable terrain. Rope bridges span the gaps between branches, while platform structures provide housing, workshops, gardens, and civic infrastructure.

You become trained in **Athletics**. If you would automatically become trained in Athletics from your background, class, or another source, you instead become trained in a skill of your choice.

DARKVISION

You can see in darkness and dim light just as well as you can see in bright light, though your vision in darkness is in black and white.

CITADEL DWARF

You're part of a renowned mining clan that tunnels into planets, moons, and asteroids for rare minerals. You become trained in **Survival**. If you would automatically become trained in Survival (from your background or class, for example), you instead become trained in a skill of your choice. When you critically succeed at a Survival check to **Earn Income** by mining, you uncover a vein of highly valuable minerals. The next time you use Survival to Earn Income in the same location, you treat the task level as 1 higher. If you're a master in Survival, you treat the task level as 2 higher, and if you're legendary in survival, you treat the task level as 4 higher. The DC for the task remains the same.

DEEP SPACE HYRNGAR

You have an attribute bonus to Charisma and a flaw to Wisdom rather than the other way around (unless you choose two free attribute boosts instead of the usual boosts and flaw). You become trained in **Deception**. If you would automatically become trained in Deception (from your background or class, for example), you instead become trained in a skill of your choice. If a creature owes you money or has caused you significant financial loss, you have a +1 circumstance bonus to Deception checks to **Lie** to them, to Perception DCs against attempts to Lie to you, and to **Intimidation** checks to **Coerce** or **Demoralize** them.

INDUSTRIAL DWARF

Whether working vast ale vats or overseeing robotics factories, your clan has long honed its trade through technology. You gain the **Additional Lore** feat for your clan's primary industry (such as **Warfare Lore**). When you **Craft** a common item of your level or lower that's associated with this industry, you automatically know the formula and can use the Lore skill in place of **Crafting**. Your proficiency in this Lore makes you eligible for Crafting skill feat prerequisites, but only while you're interacting with items related to your clan's industry.

QUESTBOUND DWARF

Your clan has dedicated itself to galactic exploration aboard a dwarven generation ship. Decades in space have left you more familiar with navigating stars than tunnels. You become trained in **Piloting**. If you would automatically become trained in Piloting (from your background or class, for example), you instead become trained in a skill of your choice. If you succeed at a Piloting check to **Navigate** or **Plot Course**, you get a critical success instead. You also gain a +1 circumstance bonus to Piloting checks made to **Recall Knowledge** about starships.